

Reading the Bible Well

PRINCIPLES OF INTERPRETATION — A REFORMED QUICK REFERENCE



START HERE: WHAT WE BELIEVE ABOUT THE BIBLE

Scripture is God's own Word, breathed out by the Spirit through human authors. It is true and trustworthy, authoritative over all of life, clear in everything needed for salvation, and sufficient — we need no other revelation to know God's saving will.

2 Tim. 3:16–17; 2 Pet. 1:20–21; Belgic Confession Art. 3–7

ELEVEN PRINCIPLES

1



LET SCRIPTURE INTERPRET SCRIPTURE

The Bible is its own best commentary. Compare a passage with other passages, and let clear texts shed light on difficult ones. Never build a doctrine on one obscure verse.

Acts 17:11; Belgic Confession Art. 7

2



READ EVERY PASSAGE IN LIGHT OF CHRIST

All of Scripture — law, history, psalms, prophets — ultimately points to Jesus and God's salvation in him. Ask: how does this passage lead me to Christ?

Luke 24:27, 44; John 5:39

3



KNOW THE PLACE IN THE ONE BIG STORY

The Bible tells a single unfolding drama: Creation → Fall → Redemption → New Creation. Locate your passage in that storyline. God's covenant of grace unites Old and New Testaments — one people, one Savior, promise and fulfillment.

Gen. 3:15; Gal. 3:8, 16, 29; Heb. 1:1–2

4



SEEK THE AUTHOR'S INTENDED MEANING

Ask what the human author, carried by the Spirit, meant to say to the original hearers. The passage cannot mean for us what it never meant for them. Meaning first; application second.

Neh. 8:8

5



TAKE THE PLAIN SENSE

Read the text in its plain, natural sense — as the genre gives it. Poetry is poetry; metaphor is metaphor. Accept the text at face value and do not hunt for hidden or coded meanings it never signals. Plain, not literalistic.

2 Cor. 4:2; Westminster Confession 1.9

6



READ IN CONTEXT

A text without context becomes a pretext. Read the verses before and after, the whole book, its historical setting, and its place in the whole Bible. Beware verses lifted out on their own.

7



RESPECT THE GENRE

Read narrative as narrative, poetry as poetry, law, prophecy, parable, letter, and apocalyptic each on their own terms. Psalms speak in images; Proverbs give wisdom, not promises; narratives describe what happened, not always what we should copy.

8



LET THE CLEAR INTERPRET THE UNCLEAR

Not everything in Scripture is equally plain, but the way of salvation is. Anchor yourself in what is certain; hold interpretations of hard passages with humility.

Ps. 119:105; 2 Pet. 3:15–16

9



READ WITH THE CHURCH, PAST AND PRESENT

The Spirit has taught the church for two thousand years. Our confessions — the Heidelberg Catechism, Belgic Confession, and Canons of Dort — are faithful summaries that guide our reading. They serve under Scripture, never over it. Read in community, not just alone.

Eph. 4:11–16; Acts 2:42

10



DEPEND ON THE HOLY SPIRIT

Understanding is not merely academic. The same Spirit who inspired the Word opens hearts to receive it. Begin with prayer; read with a willingness to obey.

Ps. 119:18; 1 Cor. 2:12–14; Heidelberg Cat. Q&A 65

11



READ TO BE TRANSFORMED, FOR ALL OF LIFE

God's Word claims every square inch of life — worship, work, family, citizenship, creation care. The goal of interpretation is not information but faith, obedience, and hope. *Jas. 1:22–25; Rom. 12:1–2*

FIVE QUESTIONS FOR ANY PASSAGE



1



WHAT DOES IT SAY?

Read slowly, twice. Note repeated words, connections ("therefore," "but"), and surprises.

2



WHAT DID IT MEAN THEN?

Who wrote it, to whom, why? What genre is it? What comes before and after?

3



WHERE IS IT IN THE STORY?

Before or after the fall? Under the old covenant or the new? How does it point to Christ?

4



WHAT DOES IT TEACH?

About God, ourselves, salvation, God's world. Does the rest of Scripture confirm my reading?

5



HOW SHALL WE RESPOND?

What is there to believe, confess, repent of, give thanks for, or do — as persons and as a church?



Your Word is a lamp to my feet
and a light to my path.

Psalms 119:105

THE 5 SOLAS



SOLI
SCRIPTURA

Scripture
Alone



SOLUS
CHRISTUS

Christ
Alone



SOLA
GRATIA

Grace
Alone



SOLA
FIDE

Faith
Alone



SOLI DEO
GLORIA

Glory to God
Alone

Soli Deo Gloria — To God Alone Be Glory



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COMMON PITFALLS TO AVOID



PROOF-TEXTING — stringing together isolated verses while ignoring their context.



MORALIZING — turning every story into “be like David” while missing the God who saves. Heroes point beyond themselves to Christ.



“WHAT IT MEANS TO ME” FIRST — jumping to personal application before asking what God actually said.



FLATTENING GENRES — reading poetry as science, proverbs as guarantees, or visions as literal prose.



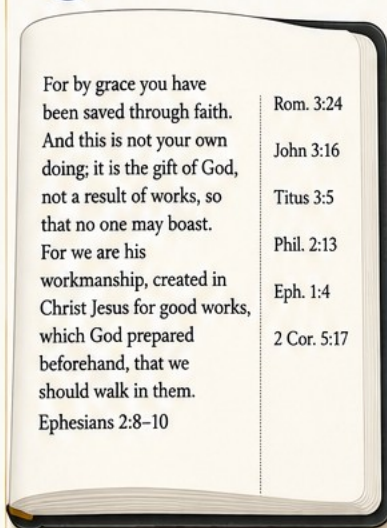
READING ALONE — ignoring the wisdom of the church, the confessions, and fellow believers.



PICKING AND CHOOSING — accepting comfortable texts and dodging hard ones. All Scripture is God’s Word.



USING CROSS-REFERENCES WELL



The small letters in your Bible’s margin are editorial helps, not part of the inspired text. They point to quotations, allusions, shared themes, or sometimes just a shared word — not all equal.

★ THE RULE: READ THE NEIGHBORHOOD.

When you jump to a cross-reference, read its surrounding paragraph too, and ask whether it truly speaks to the same question.



Free tools: a study Bible’s margin notes, **BibleHub**, or *Blue Letter Bible* (which includes the *Treasury of Scripture Knowledge*).



WORDS WORTH KNOWING



HERMENEUTICS — the principles by which we interpret Scripture.



EXEGESIS — drawing the meaning out of the text (rather than reading our ideas into it).



COVENANT — God’s binding promise-relationship with his people, fulfilled in Christ.



REDEMPTIVE-HISTORICAL — reading every passage in light of God’s unfolding plan of salvation, centered on Christ.



THE THREE FORMS OF UNITY — our confessions: the *Belgic Confession* (1561), *Heidelberg Catechism* (1563), and *Canons of Dort* (1618–19).



THE STORY IN ONE LINE



CREATION:

God made all things very good.



FALL:

Sin corrupted everything.



REDEMPTION:

In Christ, God is reconciling all things to himself.



NEW CREATION:

He will make all things new.

Gen. 1–2; Gen. 3; Col. 1:20; Rev. 21–22

THE BIBLE ASKS FIVE QUESTIONS OF EVERY PASSAGE

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SOLI SCRIPTURA • SOLUS CHRISTUS • SOLA GRATIA
SOLA FIDE • SOLI DEO GLORIA